

# YanOS

## An Operating System as Narrative Space

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*(The video documents the application experience; it is not the work itself.)*

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## Abstract

YanOS is an interface-based research artwork that reimagines the operating system as a narrative space. Instead of treating an OS only as a technical layer for running software, the project treats it as a world: a structure of memory, identity, navigation, command, failure, and return. Folders, windows, prompts, states, and logs become narrative devices. The user moves through a designed environment where computation becomes story, and story becomes system.

The current version is an interactive application prototype built as a retro desktop environment. It layers narrative content, symbolic files, custom interaction flows, and world-building on top of familiar system gestures. It is deliberately presented as a working fragment: an early version of a larger idea in which using an interface also means entering a world.

## Research Question

Can an operating system be understood as narrative architecture rather than only technical infrastructure? More specifically, how can interface design, computational structure, and autobiographical imagination combine into a system where navigation itself becomes storytelling?

## Method / Form

The project is developed as a conceptual system prototype and research-art framework. It uses the language of operating systems — windows, files, menus, logs, prompts, errors, memory, boot sequences, and user states — as artistic material. These elements are reorganized as spatial and narrative structures: the desktop becomes a surface of memory, a file becomes a trace, a command becomes an action inside a world, and an error becomes part of the story rather than a simple failure.

The work draws together computer science, interface theory, media art, and personal world-building. *YanOS* asks what happens when a user interface is treated as a stage, archive, city, and mind at the same time.

## Argument / Contribution

*YanOS* argues that contemporary interfaces already shape how people remember, decide, work, and imagine themselves. The operating system is not culturally neutral: it organizes attention, time, access, memory, and agency. By turning the OS into a narrative space, the project makes this hidden structure visible.

The contribution of the project is an *interface-fiction* model: a hybrid of conceptual operating system, digital archive, personal mythology, and interactive narrative. The aim is to test how the symbolic structure of an OS can become an artistic and philosophical medium. In this sense, *YanOS* belongs to a broader research-art practice concerned with computation as form — software not only as utility, but as a way of organizing human experience.

## What to Notice

Notice how technical language becomes spatial and narrative language: booting, opening, saving, logging, crashing, restoring, navigating. These are computer actions, but they are also metaphors for memory, identity, failure, repair, and transformation.

The key point is that *YanOS* is a system metaphor: an attempt to imagine what an operating system might become if it were designed to hold a world of symbolic movement.

## Status

Version 0.1 exhibition working paper. *YanOS* is part of an ongoing research-art practice connecting computer science, interface design, narrative systems, autobiographical archives, and public-facing digital experience.